

Ministry of Defence – Exchange Migration & Decommissioning Programme

A structured programme delivering secure, phased modernisation of legacy messaging infrastructure across defence networks.

Platform Exchange 2007 → 2013 → 2016	Scope All MoD Sites & Secure Domains
Approach Phased, Zero-Downtime Delivery	Outcome Full Legacy Decommissioning

Programme Overview

The programme was designed to deliver a seamless upgrade path while maintaining operational readiness across MoD sites and defence networks. It required meticulous planning, phased execution, and strict adherence to security and governance standards.

Key Objectives

Modernising legacy Exchange 2007 environments

Introducing Exchange 2013 as a transitional platform

Migrating all mailboxes, public folders, and services to Exchange 2016

Decommissioning legacy infrastructure post-migration

Ensuring zero disruption to mission-critical communications

Programme Structure

01

Assessment & Planning

Full audit, sequencing, and risk mitigation

02

Intermediary Migration

Exchange 2013 bridge deployment

03

Full Migration

Exchange 2016 rollout across all sites

04

Decommissioning

Legacy retirement and optimisation

Phase 1 – Assessment & Planning

A rigorous discovery and planning phase established the foundation for all subsequent delivery, ensuring that migration sequencing, coexistence strategy, and risk controls were fully defined before any infrastructure changes were made.



Environment Audit

Conducted a full audit of Exchange 2007 environments, including mailbox databases, connectors, and routing groups.



Migration Sequencing

Defined migration sequencing and coexistence strategy between 2007, 2013, and 2016 to ensure parallel operation stability.



Risk Mitigation

Developed risk mitigation plans for secure environments and classified networks, addressing MoD-specific governance requirements.



Runbooks & Rollback

Produced detailed migration runbooks and rollback procedures to safeguard operational continuity at every stage.

Phase 2 – Intermediary Migration to Exchange 2013

Exchange 2013 was deployed as a deliberate intermediary platform – a bridge architecture enabling coexistence between legacy and modern systems, validating performance and policy enforcement before the final migration to Exchange 2016.

1 Bridge Infrastructure

Built Exchange 2013 infrastructure to act as a bridge between legacy and modern systems, enabling a controlled transition path.

2 Hybrid Coexistence

Configured hybrid coexistence, enabling parallel operation of Exchange 2007 and 2013 without service interruption.

1 Pilot Validation

Migrated pilot user groups to validate performance, compatibility, and policy enforcement prior to full-scale rollout.

2 Policy & Security Baselines

Implemented new transport rules, retention policies, and security baselines aligned with MoD governance standards.

- ❏ The intermediary Exchange 2013 deployment was a critical architectural decision – it eliminated the risk of a direct 2007-to-2016 migration across classified defence networks.

Phase 3 – Full Migration to Exchange 2016

With the Exchange 2013 bridge validated and stable, the programme executed a staged, site-by-site migration to Exchange 2016 – integrating with core directory services, client platforms, and mobile device management across all MoD environments.

1

Staged Mailbox Migration

Executed staged mailbox migrations across multiple MoD sites and secure domains, minimising risk at each increment.

2

Systems Integration

Integrated Exchange 2016 with Active Directory, Outlook 2016, and mobile device management across all user populations.

3

Automation & Scripting

Delivered automated scripts for mailbox provisioning and batch migration, accelerating throughput and reducing manual error.

4

Validation & UAT

Conducted validation testing and user acceptance across departments to confirm readiness before cutover.

Phase 4 – Decommissioning & Optimisation

Following successful data migration, the programme systematically retired all legacy Exchange infrastructure, verified data integrity, and delivered a clean operational handover – reclaiming hardware resources and closing out the programme with full documentation.

1

Server Retirement

Retired Exchange 2007 and 2013 servers following successful data migration and sign-off from programme stakeholders.

1

Resource Reclamation

Reclaimed hardware resources and optimised storage utilisation, delivering measurable infrastructure efficiency gains.

2

Data Integrity & Compliance

Verified data integrity and compliance with MoD retention and audit policies across all migrated mailboxes and public folders.

2

Handover & Documentation

Delivered final documentation, operational handover, and support transition to enable sustained business-as-usual operations.

Outcomes

The programme delivered against all defined objectives, achieving a complete platform modernisation with no disruption to defence communications and full retirement of legacy infrastructure.

✓ Full Migration

Successful migration from Exchange 2007 → 2013 → 2016 across all MoD environments.

✓ Zero Downtime

Zero downtime for mission-critical communications throughout the entire programme lifecycle.

✓ Security & Compliance

Enhanced security, scalability, and compliance aligned with MoD governance and audit requirements.

✓ Simplified Management

Simplified platform management and improved user experience across all departments and sites.

✓ Legacy Retired

Full decommissioning of legacy infrastructure, reclaiming resources and eliminating technical debt.

Strategic Impact

The MoD Exchange Migration & Decommissioning Programme delivered a secure, modern, and resilient messaging platform aligned with defence communication standards.

By leveraging an intermediary migration to Exchange 2013, the programme ensured continuity, compliance, and operational stability throughout the transition – enabling the Ministry to operate with greater agility and confidence in its digital communications environment.

Continuity

Uninterrupted mission-critical communications maintained across all phases of a complex, multi-site migration.

Compliance

Full adherence to MoD retention, audit, and security governance standards throughout the programme lifecycle.

Agility

A modern Exchange 2016 platform positions the Ministry for greater operational agility and digital confidence.

Programme Principles



Security First

Every phase designed around classified network requirements and MoD governance.



Phased Delivery

Intermediary architecture eliminated direct migration risk across legacy environments.



Zero Disruption

Operational readiness preserved at every stage through rigorous planning and validation.